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Moving and shaking: Community Leaders Seder, Barbara Boxer Day in L.A. and more

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Author: Ryan Torok | Section: Los Angeles | 1559 Words
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Mayor Eric Garcetti spoke about the afikomen. City Controller Ron Galperin sang the "Song of the Partisans" — in Yiddish. Consul General of Israel in Los Angeles David Siegel welcomed everyone to spend, "Next year in Jerusalem."

At the fourth annual Community Leaders Seder, more than 100 leaders of the Jewish, Black, Korean and Latino communities gathered with community activists and elected leaders to eat, sing and learn a bit about Passover. The event, sponsored by The Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles, took place on April 12 in the rehabilitated Talmud Torah of the Breed Street Shul in Boyle Heights.

"I hope that all of us find that moment to connect with the sweetness that is the next generation, and find that piece and make it whole," Garcetti said on the meaning of the broken middle matzo.

Rabbi Noah Farkas of Valley Beth Shalom and Federation board member Jesse Gabriel led the seder, with Farkas pointing out parallels between the themes of the Passover story and the challenges L.A. faces today.

Rabbi Noah Farkas of Valley Beth Shalom and Federation board member Jesse Gabriel lead the seder.

Los Angeles City Councilman David Ryu (left) joins Daniel Gryczman at the seder.

Guests included California Treasurer John Chiang, California Secretary of State Alex Padilla, former L.A. County Supervisor Zev Yaroslavsky and his wife, Barbara, City Councilmen Marqueece Harris-Dawson, Paul Koretz and David Ryu, Federation board Chairwoman Julie Platt, Federation President and CEO Jay Sanderson, Glenn and Andrea Sonnenberg, Daniel Gryczman, Catherine Schneider, Cece Feiler, Gabriel Eshaghian, Guy Lipa, Eve Kurtin and many other leaders and activists.

— Jewish Journal staff report

Several thousand Los Angeles-area Iranian Americans of various faiths gathered in a closed-off area of Westwood known as "Persian Square" (Westwood Boulevard and Wilkins Avenue) on March 27 to celebrate the secular Persian new year of Nowruz.

Nowruz is an ancient Persian holiday marking the first day of spring and the beginning of the new year, and is celebrated by Jews, Muslims, Christians and other Iranians with a message of renewal, peace and coexistence. Festivities in Westwood this year included traditional Persian food and music, plus speeches from L.A. City Councilman Paul Koretz, Beverly Hills Mayor John A. Mirisch and L.A. City Controller Ron Galperin.

"This is a very special celebration in our area every year because very rarely [do we] see people of so many different religions come together with so much love and friendship for one another — we in the Persian community are very proud to have this kind of display of harmony," said Joe Shooshani, an Iranian-Jewish Beverly Hills Public Works commissioner.

On March 18, the L.A. City Council also celebrated Nowruz with an official Persian New Year proclamation at City Hall, which hosted several hundred Iranian-American businessmen and community leaders.

— Karmel Melamed, Contributing Writer

"Barbara Boxer Day in the City of Los Angeles" was recognized on March 23 at Los Angeles City Hall and brought together Sen. Barbara Boxer (D-Calif.) and local officials as Boxer prepares for the final months of her fourth and final term representing California in the United States Senate.

From left, front row: Eric Garcetti, Barbara Boxer, Paul Koretz; from left, middle row: Paul Krekorian, Doug Boxer, Stewart Boxer, Gilbert Cedilla, Nury Martinez, Herb Wesson Jr., Mitchell Englander, Mitch O'Farrell, Ron Galperin, Mike Bonin; from left, back row: Felipe Fuentes, Marqueece Harris-Dawson, David Ryu, Jose Huizar, Curren Price Jr. and Mike Feuer celebrate "Barbara Boxer Day." Photo courtesy of Office of Councilmember Paul Koretz.

"So honored to be at L.A. City Hall today with so many friends," Boxer, who announced in January that her current term would be her last, wrote on Twitter.

"Barbara Boxer Day" was declared by the Los Angeles City Council. Officials on hand at the event included Los Angeles Mayor Eric Garcetti, City Controller Ron Galperin, City Attorney Mike Feuer, City Council President Herb Wesson, City Councilman Paul Koretz, Boxer's son, Doug, and her husband, Stewart.

Boxer has served in Congress since 1993 and plans to retire in January. Her accomplishments include sponsoring the bipartisan U.S.-Israel Enhanced Security Cooperation Act, which was signed into law in 2012.

"Hadassah Heroes: A Celebration of Inspiration and Courage" was held on March 13 at the Beverly Hilton.

The event honored past and current Hadassah Southern California Presidents Barbara Miller-Fox Abramoff, Sherry Altura, Sharon Krischer, Soraya Nazarian, Sandra Sadikoff, Sima Schuster, Andrea Silagi, Suzanne Urfrig and Judith Weiss, as well as Patricia Gumbiner and her late husband, Jack, plus Helen and Phillip Kanter, who are described at hadassahheroes.org as Chagall Window Benefactors.

Front row, from left: Patricia Gumbiner, Barbara Miller-Fox Abramoff, Judith Weiss, Suzanne Urfrig, Soraya Nazarian, Sharon Krischer, Sandra Sadikoff and (back row, from left) Phillip and Helen Kanter, Rabbi David Wolpe, Andrea Silagi and Sima Schuster attend "Hadassah Heroes." Photo by Marvin Steindler

Comedian Avi Liberman served as the master of ceremonies.

Approximately 300 people attended the event, according to Sadikoff, the current president. Dr. Yoram Weiss, medical director of Hadassah Medical Center-Ein Kerem Hospital, was the special guest speaker, and Ellen Hershkin, president of the national board of Hadassah, the Women's Zionist Organization of America, was a special guest.

Funds raised benefited Hadassah, which describes itself as the "largest women's Zionist membership organization in the United States."

The 14th annual Cheder Menachem gala dinner, which honored the all-boys Orthodox day school's donors, was held on March 28 at Neman Hall and drew approximately 200 supporters of the school.

Cheder Menachem Director of Development Rabbi Yisroel Hecht. Photo by John Solano

"The idea is to bring people here tonight and say, 'Thank you' to them, to the people who've supported the school," Cheder Menachem board President Yossi Lipsker said in an interview following remarks by Principal Rabbi Mendel

Greenbaum, Director of Development Rabbi Yisroel Hecht and others.

The school's latest fundraising campaign raised $500,000, Lipsker said.

The event featured entertainment from performer Simon Sez (Sholom Hyman), who led a game of Simon Says, with winners taking home Western Kosher and Glatt Mart gift certificates, as well as an iPad.

Indicative of the school's connection with the Chabad-Lubavitch movement, a framed photo of the Lubavitcher Rebbe Menachem Mendel Schneerson, the spiritual founder of the school, was placed on the stage of the West Hollywood banquet hall.

Shmuel Fogelman, a school board member, said he hopes Cheder Menachem will continue to play an important role in the education of his family.

"My children went to the school and hopefully my grandchildren will go to the school," he said during the dessert reception.

Approximately 300 students, grades one through eight, are enrolled at Cheder Menachem, which is located on South La Cienega Boulevard.

Beth Chayim Chadashim (House of New Life) held an awards brunch at the Skirball Cultural Center on April 10. The annual gathering, which drew 200 attendees, recognized nonprofit leader Gwen Walden with the Rabbi Erwin and Agnes Herman Humanitarian Award; same-sex marriage advocates Evan Wolfson and Marc Solomon with the Harriet Perl Tzedek Award; and former BCC board member Larry Nathenson with the BCC Presidents Award.

Rabbi Lisa Edwards said BCC honored Wolfson and Solomon for their "visionary and instrumental roles bringing about fundamental change by embedding the freedom to marry in our nation's Constitution."

Wolfson founded the advocacy group Freedom to Marry, and Solomon, who spent five years as national campaign director for Freedom to Marry, is a political strategist who worked for 12 years in pursuit of victories on same-sex marriage at the state and national levels.

Established in 1972, BCC holds the distinction of being the first synagogue for the gay and lesbian community. Today, BCC identifies as "progressive" and draws community members of all backgrounds.

The Havdalah flame of the fourth annual Coachella Shabbat Tent — otherwise known as "ChallahChella" — lit up the first weekend of this year's Coachella Valley Music and Arts Festival in Indio, a three-day festival that takes place over two consecutive weekends.

Siblings Yaakov and Miriam Sobel volunteering at the Coachella Shabbat Tent this past weekend, which was held at the Coachella Valley Music and Arts Festival. Photos by Brian Feinzimer

Pico Shul's Rabbi Yonah Bookstein participates in a kiddush at the April 15-17 Coachella Valley Music and Arts Festival as part of the fourth annual Coachella Shabbat Tent, dubbed "ChallahChella."

Pico Shul Rabbi Yonah Bookstein, co-founder of Shabbat Tent, said in an email that he was "jamming on my guitar during our huge havdalah circle as thousands of people streamed out of the festival entrance after 1 a.m. when Guns n Roses finished."

Shabbat Tent, run by Bookstein and his wife, Rachel, provides festivalgoers an opportunity to experience such

events Jewishly. The rabbi said more than 3,000 people stopped by the Shabbat Tent this past weekend and enjoyed wine, challah, Shabbat meals and more.

Bookstein, for his part, said the highlight was the Saturday night ceremony, during which the sounds of Havdalah competed with the thumping bass of electronic dance music. It was "a magical moment," he said.

To view additional photos of ChallahChella, click here.

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